

Neither Absent nor Ambient: Incidental News Exposure From the Perspective of News Avoiders in the UK, United States, and Spain

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Abstract

Scholars have long argued that incidental news exposure (INE) is a potentially valuable way citizens gain political information and learn about current affairs. Yet growing scholarship on news avoidance suggests many people still manage to consume little news, and algorithmic curation may decrease the likelihood that they will be exposed to it incidentally. In this article, we put the literatures on INE, news avoidance, and political talk into dialogue with one another. Then, by inductively analyzing over a hundred in-depth interviews conducted from 2016 to 2020 with news avoiders in the UK, Spain, and the United States, we explore how they encounter news incidentally and to what extent they feel the news is accessible and available to them. Our audience-centric approach highlights that interviewees often did not make a clear distinction between direct encounters with professional news (“firsthand news”) and discussions of news (“secondhand news”), especially online. When they did make a distinction, the latter was often more salient for them. We also find that just as news consumers have repertoires of news sources on which they habitually rely, news avoiders have repertoires of sources for incidental exposure to news to stay informed about major events and anything that might affect them directly. And yet, those repertoires catch only the biggest and most sensational stories of the day and do little to help them contextualize or understand the news they encounter, contributing to their sense that news is neither entirely absent nor ambient in the way scholars have theorized.

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In a digital world in which news is ambient—ever present and always accessible (Hermida 2010)—some degree of incidental news exposure (INE) seems inevitable. Since scholars have argued that INE is a valuable way for citizens to learn about current affairs (e.g., Downs 1957; Zukin and Snyder 1984; Nanz and Matthes 2022), this would seem a positive development that could reduce gaps in political engagement. Yet growing scholarship on news avoidance suggests many people still manage to consume little news (e.g., Edgerly 2021; Palmer and Toff 2020; Skovsgaard and Andersen 2020; Villi et al. 2021), reflecting widening disparities around news use that may be exacerbated by algorithmic curation (Thorson 2020). What are the means, then, by which news avoiders stay informed? And under what circumstances do they experience INE?

In this article, we put the literatures on INE and news avoidance into dialogue with one another, along with the third literature on political talk. By inductively analyzing over a hundred in-depth interviews with news avoiders (defined as people who access news less than once-a-month) in three countries (the UK, Spain, and the United States), we explore how they perceive their incidental encounters with news and whether news feels as accessible and available to them as scholarship on “ambient news” suggests it might.

Although INE research usually focuses on exposure to professionally produced news, our audience-centric approach highlights that our interviewees often did not make a clear distinction between direct encounters with professional news (what we call “firsthand news”) and discussions of news (“secondhand news”), especially online. When they did make a distinction, the latter was often more salient for them. We also find that just as news consumers have repertoires of news sources on which they habitually rely, news avoiders have repertoires of INE involving the people they converse with and places they go, which allow them to stay informed about major events. Those repertoires catch the biggest and most sensational stories of the day, contributing to a sense that news is not entirely absent (as in, e.g., Thorson 2020), but they do little to help contextualize the news people encounter, in contrast to theories about “ambient” news which describe it as empowering (Hargreaves 2003; Hermida 2010).

Our findings suggest that INE research focusing only on exposure to professionally produced news may be neglecting a key way—if not *the* key way—that people who do not intentionally seek out news learn about current affairs: through exposure to on- and offline conversations about such topics. We conclude that our interviewees’ heavy reliance on secondhand news could raise concerns about their susceptibility to misinformation, but it may also indicate avenues for further engagement with news and civic life.

Literature Review

INE

In what is often cited as an early conceptualization of INE, Downs (1957) distinguished between news that people seek out intentionally, which is costly in time and resources, and less costly news they bump into by accident, when chatting with neighbors, for example. In this conception, incidental exposure does not require exposure to professionally produced news, but rather includes a conversation about current affairs and politics, as in Katz and Lazarsfeld's (1955) two-step flow. Over time, however, research on INE and studies of discussion of news and politics diverged. For normative and methodological reasons, INE research began to define the concept narrowly as unintentional exposure to professionally produced news—what we call “firsthand news.”

Early INE scholars explored how people who were not interested in the news might see it anyway while they waited to watch other programs or flipped channels in search of entertainment, “passively learning” from the news they happened upon (Blumler and McQuail 1968; Krugman and Hartley 1970; Zukin and Snyder 1984). This literature developed alongside research on “media repertoires,” defined first by Heeter (1985) as the sets of channels that people visited routinely while watching television. As the array of media choices expanded, Prior (2007) argued that these repertoires began to diverge along lines of interest in news, with those who preferred entertainment able to adopt repertoires that limited both deliberate and incidental exposure to news.

The continued expansion of choices via digital and social media has prompted additional scholarship on INE, much of it focused on how INE affects competencies like political learning and engagement (e.g., Kaiser, Keller, and Kleinen-von Königsöw 2021; Lee and Kim 2017; Nanz and Matthes 2022; Valeriani and Vaccari 2016). While some studies have shown that people can learn basic information about current events from incidental exposure to firsthand news (Bode 2016; Lee and Kim 2017; Oeldorf-Hirsch 2018), research also suggests that INE most benefits people who are already interested in politics because they are more likely to engage with the news stories they come across (Kim, Chen, and Gil de Zúñiga 2013; Karnowski et al. 2017). For people who do not *want* to come across political information on social media, such forms of exposure can trigger reactance and even avoidance (Marcinkowski and Došenović 2021).

Social networks can play an important role in INE—for example, spurring discussions about news people are exposed to incidentally (Ardèvol-Abreu, Diehl, and Gil De Zúñiga 2017). Some studies find that people with more heterogeneous networks and more weak ties report more incidental exposure (Lee and Kim 2017). However, people are more likely to engage with and learn from news shared by strong ties (Anspach 2017; Kaiser, Keller, and Kleinen-von Königsöw 2021), suggesting people whose strong ties are interested in news and politics likely get more out of INE online.

Indeed, since INE online is shaped by a combination of personal, social, and algorithmic curation (Thorson and Wells 2016), some scholars argue it widens gaps between the politically interested and uninterested (Kümpel 2020). Preferences learned early in life shape what individuals engage with, which in turn trains algorithms to predict what they will like (Thorson, Xu, and Edgerly 2018). This, along with indicators like their friends' interests, can lead algorithms to categorize people as uninterested in news and show them less of it, prompting Thorson (2020) to ask about the implications for those less likely to "attract" news on social media—that is, whether and how INE might occur among those least interested in news.

News Avoiders

The phenomenon of news avoidance offers a lens through which to examine precisely that question. News avoidance has been the focus of a growing number of recent studies, although their different ways of operationalizing it have led to a range of answers to key questions like how common it is, who avoids news, and why. Some studies, for example, classify people as news avoiders if they consume very little news, either relative to others in their country or using an absolute measure (Edgerly 2017; Ksiazek, Malthouse, and Webster 2010; Strömbäck 2017; Palmer and Toff 2020; Toff and Palmer 2019). These studies emphasize individual and structural factors that predict news avoidance, such as gender, age, low socioeconomic status, low political efficacy, and low interest in politics (Edgerly 2021; Ksiazek, Malthouse, and Webster 2010; Strömbäck 2017; Toff and Palmer 2019). Other studies use "news avoidance" to describe intentional efforts to take breaks from the news or curtail exposure (e.g., Villi et al. 2021). These studies find that factors driving news avoidance include perceptions that news is too negative, too irrelevant, or untrustworthy (Kalogeropoulos 2017; Newman et al. 2019), and critiques about the information environment (Park 2019; Song, Jung, and Kim 2016; Toff and Kalogeropoulos 2020; Villi et al. 2021).

In an effort to clarify conceptual fuzziness around the term news avoidance, Skovsgaard and Andersen (2020) advocate the following definition: "low news consumption over a continuous period of time caused either by a dislike for news (intentional) or a higher preference for other content (unintentional)" (p. 5). By this definition, people may be considered news avoiders as long as they habitually consume very little news, whether intentionally or not. Although some scholars argue that there are important differences between people who avoid news intentionally and those who do not (Betakova et al. 2021), in the present study and the larger news avoidance project from which these data are drawn, we employ the more expansive definition because, as we argue elsewhere (Palmer and Toff 2022), making distinctions around underlying intentions is very difficult in practice. Those who habitually access minimal news (rather than those who selectively tune out) also better correspond to the population at the core of the question Thorson (2020) raises about how INE occurs among those least likely to encounter it.

While some studies have examined how news avoiders use alternative strategies to get information, such as relying on trusted informants (Toff and Palmer 2019), looking up government websites (Edgerly 2017), or “just Googling” information (Toff and Nielsen 2018), such work has not focused on incidental exposure. We therefore take this as our first framing question:

Q1: How are news avoiders incidentally exposed to firsthand (professionally produced) news?

Secondhand News Through Political Talk

A separate line of research examining how people learn about current affairs has focused less on exposure to professionally produced news and more on conversation as a source of exposure to *information* about current events and politics (e.g., Eveland, Morey, and Hutchens 2011; Lupia and McCubbins 1998). Studies find that political talk with more knowledgeable, like-minded informants can lead to as much learning as accessing news directly (Carlson 2019). However, information gleaned through conversation often includes a narrower range of viewpoints than professional news (Carlson 2019; Mutz and Martin 2001), can become less accurate when transmitted (Carlson 2018; Moussaïd, Brighton, and Gaissmaier 2015), and is often biased (Druckman, Levendusky, and McLain 2018).

These casual conversations about news and politics increasingly take place using social media and messaging platforms primarily used for connecting with others (Swart, Peters, and Broersma 2017) and voicing opinions (Valeriani and Vaccari 2018). These conversations have been linked to political engagement online and offline, although studies of their relationship to political knowledge have produced mixed results (Valenzuela, Bachmann, and Bargsted 2019; Yamamoto, Kushin, and Dalisay 2018). Taken together, findings suggest that talk about current affairs—what we call “secondhand news,” as one of our interviewees referred to it—may not be a perfect substitute for encountering news directly, but is likely better than nothing for boosting awareness about civic issues.

While political talk and INE have largely been studied as separate phenomena, recent audience-centric, qualitative studies examine how people subjectively experience exposure to news (e.g., Boczkowski, Mitchelstein, and Matassi 2018; Mitchelstein et al. 2020; Yadamsuren and Erdelez 2017) raise questions about drawing sharp distinctions between encounters with first- and secondhand news. From users’ perspectives, the two blur together, especially on social media. In interviews across five countries, one study found that “most respondents did not recall the names of news organizations when describing bumping into information, and thus, tend not to distinguish between the ‘message’ and the ‘source’,” rather recalling the source as simply “on Facebook” (Mitchelstein et al. 2020: 1143; see also Boczkowski, Mitchelstein, and Matassi 2018).

In light of the findings from these studies we take the following as our second framing question:

Q2: How are news avoiders incidentally exposed to secondhand news (conversations about news on and offline), and to what extent do they distinguish between first- and secondhand news?

News Exposure in a Digital World

Our third framing question concerns perceptions about the presence of news in the digital media environment. While news is almost by definition absent for news avoiders, it does not necessarily follow that it feels that way. Some scholars argue that news today is simply “ambient” or constantly available whether one is focused on it or not. For example, Hermida (2010) defines ambient journalism as “an awareness system” that is “always-on,” offering a “diverse means to collect, communicate, share and display news and information, serving diverse purposes” (p. 301). This implies an empowering scenario for users, insofar as news is present and accessible in so many ways that it is simply there for-the-taking for everyone. In a more negative take, Gil de Zúñiga, Weeks, and Ardèvol-Abreu (2017) argue that if people are overconfident that news will simply “find them,” they may not bother to seek it out, reducing political knowledge. This research raises the possibility that, even for people who have little interest in news, news may nonetheless feel ambient—so much so that it needs to be actively avoided. Studies linking news avoidance to news overload would seem to corroborate that (Park 2019; Song, Jung, and Kim 2016).

On the other hand, some research suggests that perceptions about news being ever-present may not be universal. As Prior (2007) argued, the high choice landscape allows people who prefer entertainment to more easily adopt media repertoires that exclude news. Likewise, studies show that most people in fact consume minimal news—particularly online (Hindman 2018; Thurman 2018). This is consistent with the INE research described above that finds algorithmic curation may decrease the likelihood that people uninterested in news will be exposed to it (Kümpel 2020; Thorson 2020). That suggests that for news avoiders news may well feel more absent than ambient. We take this as our third framing question:

Q3: To what extent do news avoiders perceive news as absent or ambient?

Method

This article is based on interviews conducted as part of a larger study designed to better understand how news avoiders, defined as people who consume little-to-no news, whether intentionally or unintentionally, think and feel about news, why they do not consume it more, and how they manage without it.¹ Findings are based on in-depth interviews with 108 working-to-middle-class people in the UK ($N=43$), Spain ($N=40$), and the United States ($N=25$) who said on a screener survey that they consumed news “less than once-a-month” or “never.”² We focused on this lower socioeconomic bracket because extremely low news consumption is rare among people of higher socioeconomic status (Edgerly 2021; Geers 2020), but also for normative reasons. Since

news consumption has long been tied to political knowledge and engagement (e.g., Norris 2000; Strömbäck and Shehata 2010), we were concerned that extremely low news consumption might further disadvantage people in lower socioeconomic strata.

We chose to compare people in the UK, Spain, and the United States because they strike the balance between similarity and difference that is necessary for productive comparisons (Sartori 1991): they are all large, wealthy, industrialized democracies, but have different political contexts and media systems (Brüggemann et al. 2014). Following best practices for comparative research, as much as possible we followed the same procedures for recruitment, interviewing, and analysis in all three countries (Esser 2013). Market research firms identified, screened, and recruited participants primarily in Leeds and Manchester in the UK; in Madrid in Spain; and in the Des Moines and Cedar Rapids areas in Iowa in the United States.

Following the same interview guide, we, the authors (residing in each country at the time), conducted the hour-long, semi-structured interviews in participants' homes, except for a small number conducted by phone or in public locales like cafes. Interviews were not designed to focus on INE, but rather to understand, in a bottom-up, audience-centric manner how interviewees thought about and related to news. Interviews thus covered participants' daily routines and media habits; what they considered to be the most important problems for their country, their community, and in their own lives; their main sources of information; and their thoughts about journalism.

We took an inductive approach derived from grounded theory for the data collection and analysis, so interviews evolved over time as new theoretical constructs emerged (Charmaz 2014). All interviews were recorded and transcribed, and we coded them in a multistage collaborative process using NVivo software. Interviewees were assigned pseudonyms, and we have translated Spanish quotes. (See online Supplemental material file for original quotes, participant lists, interview protocols, and additional coding information).

We conducted the UK interviews from November 2016 to March 2017, just after the Brexit referendum and the election of Donald Trump. We then conducted ten follow-up interviews in June 2017 following a snap general election. We found it useful to speak to people who consumed almost no news during times of heightened political tension when such events dominated the news, so in Spain, we conducted interviews from October 2017 to February 2018, right after the controversial referendum on Catalan secession. In the United States, we conducted interviews in Iowa in the summer of 2019, during the campaign season leading up to the 2020 presidential election, with 10 follow-up interviews in February 2020 just following the primaries in Iowa.

We highlight the timeline because during periods like these, of intense media coverage surrounding major political events, it is especially likely that people will be incidentally exposed to news (Mitchelstein et al. 2020). While that is useful for identifying forms of INE, under more routine political conditions some of the forms of INE that we identify below would probably be less common. We do not claim strict generalizability of our findings from this relatively small-*N* study. Instead, we argue our findings are

logically generalizable in the sense that they likely apply to similar populations in similar places (Luker 2008).

Although these findings come from a cross-national comparative study, in this paper, we focus more on patterns that recurred across countries than we do on country-level differences. As we will show, the main differences we found regarding INE were not on the media system/country level. They were due to differences in lifestyle and infrastructure—in the places people go, with whom they interact, and the tools they use—that varied within countries as well as across them.

Findings

Q1: How are news avoiders incidentally exposed to firsthand (professionally produced) news?

Consistent with research that finds that interest in politics is a strong predictor of news consumption (Lecheler and de Vreese 2017; Prior 2007), we found that almost all of our interviewees said they were uninterested in politics or actively disliked it, and had not engaged much with politics in the past. As Ryan, a stay-at-home dad in the UK put it, “I hate politics. It’s probably one of the reasons I don’t read the news, to be honest.” Most did not identify strongly with any political party, and many said they did not vote. They also did not belong to communities (social, familial, or professional) that talked a lot about news. Not all interviewees said they intentionally avoided news, although many did.

Given these characteristics, we should not expect our interviewees to encounter much firsthand news, and relatively speaking, they did not. Some felt they were barely exposed to news of any kind at all. But many said they were incidentally exposed to firsthand news sporadically, often in ways that recall pre-digital studies of INE. Quite a few described brushes with news on broadcast or cable television, despite mainly relying on streaming services. Some of that exposure occurred because they lived with or visited someone—often a parent or grandparent—who liked to watch TV news. Others described the classic INE scenario of catching bits of news on TV between preferred programs, or, especially in the United States where commuting by car was more common, on the radio. Station choices were highly dependent on who else was in the car. As Melanie, an employee at a diabetes clinic in the United States, said, “On my way to work I’ll listen to the radio, but we carpool most of the days and either listen to music or he [her partner] listens to CNN. He would have it on all the time.”

Exposure to little bits of firsthand news in public places was also fairly common. Interviewees described catching, as Caleb (UK) put it, “a cheeky look” at newspaper headlines on public transit or at the supermarket, or glimpsing TV news in waiting rooms, bars, or cafes. For example, in Spain, Pedro, who worked in construction, said he ate lunch every day in a cafeteria where the TV was tuned to news. He found himself drawn into coverage of political corruption despite his best efforts to

avoid it. He explained, “You see the rolling headlines, you see the subtitles, you see the stories and of course you get upset even if you don’t want to... I sit with my back to the television, but of course you hear comments.”

Recent research suggests that, due to algorithmic curation, people like our interviewees would be unlikely to see much news on social media (Kümpel 2020; Thorson 2020). In fact, many of our interviewees said they did, but usually in the form of conversations about news rather than firsthand news, so we discuss it further in the next section. Regarding other forms of digital exposure to firsthand news, some interviewees said they inadvertently saw headlines through alerts, apps, or widgets that “just popped up” on their phones either by default or because they had inadvertently installed them. For example, Daniel (US), who worked in sales, said Apple News sometimes appeared on his phone when he swiped by accident, but “just because I haven’t spent the time to figure out how to shut it off.”

Interviewees acknowledged that they gleaned some basic information from headlines and other bits of firsthand news that they saw and overheard, but they rarely clicked or sought more information. As many of the quotes above indicate, they often found them more annoying than helpful. These, after all, were bits and pieces of the very types of news that they chose not to seek out and in some cases intentionally avoided.

Q2: How are news avoiders exposed to secondhand news (conversations about news on and offline), and to what extent do they distinguish between first- and secondhand news?

The most common forms of incidental exposure that interviewees mentioned—those on which they most relied to find out what they really needed to know—were not firsthand news. They were secondhand sources. These included conversations on social media or WhatsApp, but offline word of mouth was by far the most common. Even the most politically disengaged interviewees said that conversation was an important way they found out about current affairs and politics—sometimes the only way. As Iris (Spain), a stay-at-home mom, explained, “Many times I’ve said to my husband, one of these days we’re going to get up and there will be a war and we won’t know about it. I mean, if someone doesn’t tell us we don’t find out about things, that’s the truth.”

Different interviewees were exposed to different levels of word-of-mouth news, almost like concentric circles radiating out from their homes. Some had a spouse, family member, or close friend who followed news more closely than they did, and whom they trusted to keep them informed, two-step flow style (Katz and Lazarsfeld 1955). Dion, a health aide in the United States, recounted getting a text message from a friend “who’s big into politics and current events” letting her know that an old friend was in the news for having killed his own father. Those who worked in offices gleaned current events information from brief chats with colleagues during breaks or slow periods. As Ed (US), an engineer, explained, “A quick drop, you know, at the start of a meeting. Someone just starts small talk, someone brings

something up.” He added that he had “no clue” that a mass shooting had occurred until someone mentioned it at work.

As noted above, interviewees did sometimes see firsthand news on social media in the form of headlines. More often, though, they recalled *conversations* about current events they saw on social media. In Spain, where WhatsApp is widespread, many interviewees said they learned about politics from satirical memes circulating in WhatsApp group chats. In the other countries, interviewees more often mentioned Facebook, Twitter, and Instagram as their main sources for exposure to online conversations about current events. These conversations sometimes appeared to include the sharing of news articles and headlines—so the line between the two *was* blurry—but what stuck with interviewees was the sense that “everyone was talking about it.” For example, Carly, who worked in sales in the United States, said local tax spending was one of the main issues facing her community and that “most of the time when I hear people talking about it, it’s on social media. Giving a strong opinion either for or against something, or sharing a news headline.” She added, “I don’t click into the news headline.”

Carly was typical: interviewees said they rarely clicked or engaged with current events or political news they saw on social media. They usually just read the headlines and got a gist of the commentary, and some made it clear they preferred to avoid that, too. When they did click, it was usually because the story was too massive or nearby to ignore—terrorist attacks or mass shootings in their vicinity, for example—or because they felt pressure to get informed because an issue had generated so much discussion that they felt left out. This was another way that secondhand news appeared to have more of an impact on them than firsthand news. For example, Andrea, a house cleaner in the UK, recalled of an upcoming general election that, “I wasn’t all that interested, but I did then start watching and reading things because my friends were posting things on Facebook, and they were debating, and I felt like I couldn’t join in.”

Some interviewees said they were turned off by heated conversations about current events on social media. However, they generally seemed more receptive to learning about news through secondhand sources than firsthand sources, especially from close individual informants, whom they found more efficient, understandable, and trustworthy than firsthand news sources, and whom they could ask questions about issues they had seen but did not understand. For example, Paloma, a thirty-seven-year-old teacher in Spain, said she saw people joking on WhatsApp about Catalan independence, “and then I say to my husband, ‘This thing they’re talking about...?’ and he catches me up.”

Q3: To what extent do news avoiders perceive news as absent or ambient?

We found a spectrum among interviewees around how they perceived the news environment. For some, like Iris (Spain, mentioned above), news did feel almost entirely absent. She was raising young children and said her main concern was just making ends meet. She recalled finding out about a big news story—a terrorist cell discovered in her neighborhood—only because a neighbor had told her husband.

Occasionally big stories reached her on social media as well, but news was largely non-existent in her day to day. Other interviewees said news did seem ambient. They tended to be people whose social networks discussed news more often. For example, despite his professed dislike of politics, Ryan (UK) seemed well informed about some current issues. It turned out his wife followed news closely, and he had friends who liked to discuss some issues as well. He said “Basically, I never actually seek any information out. It’s just like osmosis. It just gets in there somehow.”

As Hermida (2010) originally conceived it, ambient news is a resource for people to take advantage of at any time. However, interviewees like Ryan who felt news was ambient usually did not experience this ambience as an advantage, but rather as a kind of aggravating buzz that they took pains to turn off or tune out. Some had intentionally taken themselves off social networks, and many avoided conversations about news and politics because they found them upsetting or confusing—often too infused with competing views that they felt unqualified to judge. For example, Gracie, an antique dealer in the UK, said she found out about news mostly through word of mouth, but she took deliberate steps to dull the roar, like not owning a TV and selectively avoiding conversations about it. She explained, “I think honestly in life everything’s quite difficult anyway....I just haven’t got the time to sift through all of the information to work out what’s true and what’s not.”

Like Gracie, many interviewees said they struggled with some combination of difficult life circumstances, such as managing long-term illness, unemployment, or heavy caretaking responsibilities. Many also described themselves as having particularly anxious or nervous personalities, and, as noted above, many also had little past experience with news and politics. Given these factors, they perceived consuming firsthand news as especially costly in terms of time, emotional energy, and mental effort. For example, Joanna (US), who was raising and homeschooling her small children, said the main reason she avoided news was, “Probably anxiety...I’ve dealt with depression and anxiety for years...news doesn’t help.”

Instead of consuming news directly, Joanna counted on her husband to keep her informed. Other interviewees counted on a different set of incidental sources. These were not news repertoires in the classical sense, because interviewees did not deliberately seek out news. But they did have repertoires of INE in the sense that they followed routines—whether it was commuting by public transit, eating in cafes, talking to specific people, or using social media—that resulted in reliable exposure to news in consistent ways. Depending on the person, these repertoires of INE included a variety of firsthand and secondhand sources and acted as a kind of net to catch the stories they needed to know—a warning system to alert them about major news stories or anything that might affect them directly (Zaller 2003). For people who felt they saw almost no news in their daily lives, INE repertoires helped them feel news was not entirely absent—at least not the big stories. For those who found news aggravatingly ambient, INE repertoires helped them navigate the clutter and reduce what felt like an incomprehensible chatter to one or a few voices they felt they could rely on to stay at least minimally informed.

For example, Rodolfo, a web developer in Spain, said political corruption was an important topic to him. When we asked how he learned about it he responded, “The same as almost everything I’ve told you. From clips that someone sends on WhatsApp, some story; word-of-mouth conversations, and the TV at coffee hour at work.” Rodolfo did not seek out current events information, but time had taught him he could rely on those three sources. In the United States, Carly had a different repertoire, but the effect was the same. She explained, that “I do listen to a lot of podcasts, but not political podcasts...it’s a lot of science podcasts.” But they did sometimes mention news, and so, she went on, “I get secondhand news from podcasts. From hearing my husband or friends talk about things. A lot of it is headlines that are being shared on social media.”

Even though most interviewees were fairly confident that major stories would reach them via their INE repertoires, they did not appear to feel overconfident in their knowledge—a concern raised about “news-finds-me” perceptions (Gil de Zúñiga, Weeks, and Ardèvol-Abreu 2017). By relying on their INE repertoires, interviewees did believe that news would “find them”—but only the news that “everyone was talking about.” That mainly meant the *big* news stories (like Brexit, Catalan independence, or Trump’s election) and sensational stories (like mass shootings or corruption scandals), but left out a lot of news that makes for less compelling gossip: policy discussion, for example, or the contextual material that helps people make sense of those big stories. State employee Brian (US), for example, said he sometimes read the news alerts that popped up by accident on his phone but, “I’d say I’m more of a headline guy, read the headline and read the headline and that’s it. So I can’t tell you a lot about it.” Other interviewees recalled moments when important information slipped through their INE net. Olga, an administrator in Spain, for example, recalled a recent drive to work when she had thought, “How slow everyone is today,” as she sped past, only to find out later that she had missed the news that speed limits were restricted due to pollution controls.

Some interviewees said they wished they knew more or even felt embarrassed that they did not, but ultimately most were satisfied with the system they had in place to keep minimally informed. The strategy felt much less costly than consuming news directly from professional sources—which they did not find interesting anyway. Take the example of Alex, a physical education student in Spain, who said he relied on WhatsApp as one of his main sources of news, “because really I don’t usually look it up, I’m not interested, not at all.” He said it was through joke memes on WhatsApp that he learned about the fugitive Catalan leader Carles Puigdemont. But the knowledge he acquired was quite limited—not much beyond “that he’s named Puigdemont and that they’re looking for him to put him in jail and [laughs] nothing else.”

Discussion

The news avoiders we interviewed were incidentally exposed to both firsthand and secondhand news, but the latter tended to be much more salient. Consistent with audience-centric approaches to INE that do not look specifically at news avoiders (Mitchelstein

et al. 2020), often our interviewees did not distinguish between firsthand and second-hand news: they heard about news stories most often because “everyone was talking about them” either on- or offline. Our findings suggest that narrowly focusing on INE as exposure only to firsthand news, as INE research has traditionally done, will miss an important way that people with low interest in news and politics stay informed (albeit often only minimally so) and how they make sense of the firsthand news that they do encounter: through discussion.

On the one hand, in light of past research, our interviewees’ heavy reliance on second-hand news could raise concerns. People may become overconfident or outright misinformed based on social exchanges in which information may be partial, biased, or inaccurate (Druckman, Levendusky, and McLain 2018; Gil de Zúñiga, Weeks, and Ardèvol-Abreu 2017; Yamamoto, Kushin, and Dalisay 2018). Furthermore, much of the secondhand news our interviewees were exposed to was on social media or messaging platforms, where misinformation often circulates (Bradshaw and Howard 2019). Indeed, while our interviewees did not seem overconfident in the knowledge gleaned from second-hand sources, they also did not feel it left them well-equipped to judge firsthand news or incoming current affairs and political information more generally.

That said, a healthy democracy does not require that all citizens be news enthusiasts, only that they stay attuned to alarm bells alerting them to important issues (Schudson 1998; Zaller 2003). Many interviewees also felt that their repertoires of INE, in which secondhand sources figured prominently, served this function. We also found that social pressure, or a sense that everyone was talking about something, was one of the few reasons interviewees said they felt compelled to seek out more information about the news they encountered. This is consistent with INE research that finds that exposure to news shared by strong ties can lead to more engagement with the news itself (Anspach 2017; Kaiser, Keller, and Kleinen-von Königsöw 2021) as well as research on political talk, which finds it often beneficial for political engagement (e.g., Carlson 2019; Valenzuela, Bachmann, and Bargsted 2019). In other words, secondhand news may act as a gateway to exposure to firsthand news, although it is difficult to assess how often this occurred using our methodology. Overall, these findings suggest that while secondhand news may not always be preferable to firsthand news normatively speaking, it certainly warrants further study as a form of incidental exposure to information in the news. If the aim is to narrow gaps between those who are already informed and engaged and those who are not, our findings point hopefully toward ways in which deepening engagement with political information may be possible, even among extreme news avoiders.

That our interviewees had similar behaviors toward news but perceived the availability of news in a range of ways—from mostly absent to aggravatingly ambient—highlights the value of research into the connection between perceptions of the news environment and behaviors around news use. Research on news-finds-me perceptions (Gil de Zúñiga, Weeks, and Ardèvol-Abreu 2017) and news overload (Park 2019; Song, Jung, and Kim 2016) explores these connections, but our findings underscore that different populations may respond to these perceptions in different ways, depending on social and structural factors.

For example, scholars raise concerns that the “news-finds-me” perception can lead to overconfidence in one’s knowledge of current events (Gil de Zúñiga, Weeks, and Ardèvol-Abreu 2017). Although our interviewees were confident that their various INE repertoires would catch major news stories or stories that might affect them directly, they were also aware that this approach caught only the biggest stories of the day and they often felt ill-prepared to understand or interpret the news they encountered in this way. Many interviewees felt overwhelmed by the demands of their lives. Because they had little background knowledge from past engagement, even dissecting news they encountered incidentally—news that Downs (1957) characterized as low-cost and effortless—felt relatively costly in terms of time and resources. These findings underscore that the moment of exposure to news (the focus of many INE studies) matters, but many structural and social factors may matter more in determining how people will receive the news they are exposed to, and these need to be taken into account if we are to understand how INE is experienced, and why it may or may not have effects at all.

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Supplemental Material

Supplemental material for this article is available online.

Notes

1. This research was approved by the review boards at the University of Oxford (reference #R48688), IE University (reference #IERC-01-2017-2018), and the University of Minnesota (reference #STUDY00006810).
2. The survey question was adopted from previous research (Newman et al. 2017). The UK and United States: “Typically, how often do you access news? By news we mean national, international, regional/local news and other topical events accessed via any platform (radio,

TV, newspaper or online)." Spain: "Normalmente, ¿con qué frecuencia consulta las noticias? Por noticias nos referimos a la información nacional, internacional, regional/local y otros acontecimientos de actualidad consultados en cualquier plataforma (radio, televisión, periódicos o Internet)." The vast majority of participants met the stringent "less-than-once-a-month" requirement for news consumption except for one individual in the UK and seven in the United States who consumed news "less-than-once-a-week." Eligibility requirements were loosened due to challenges locating enough participants who fit the stricter parameters.

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